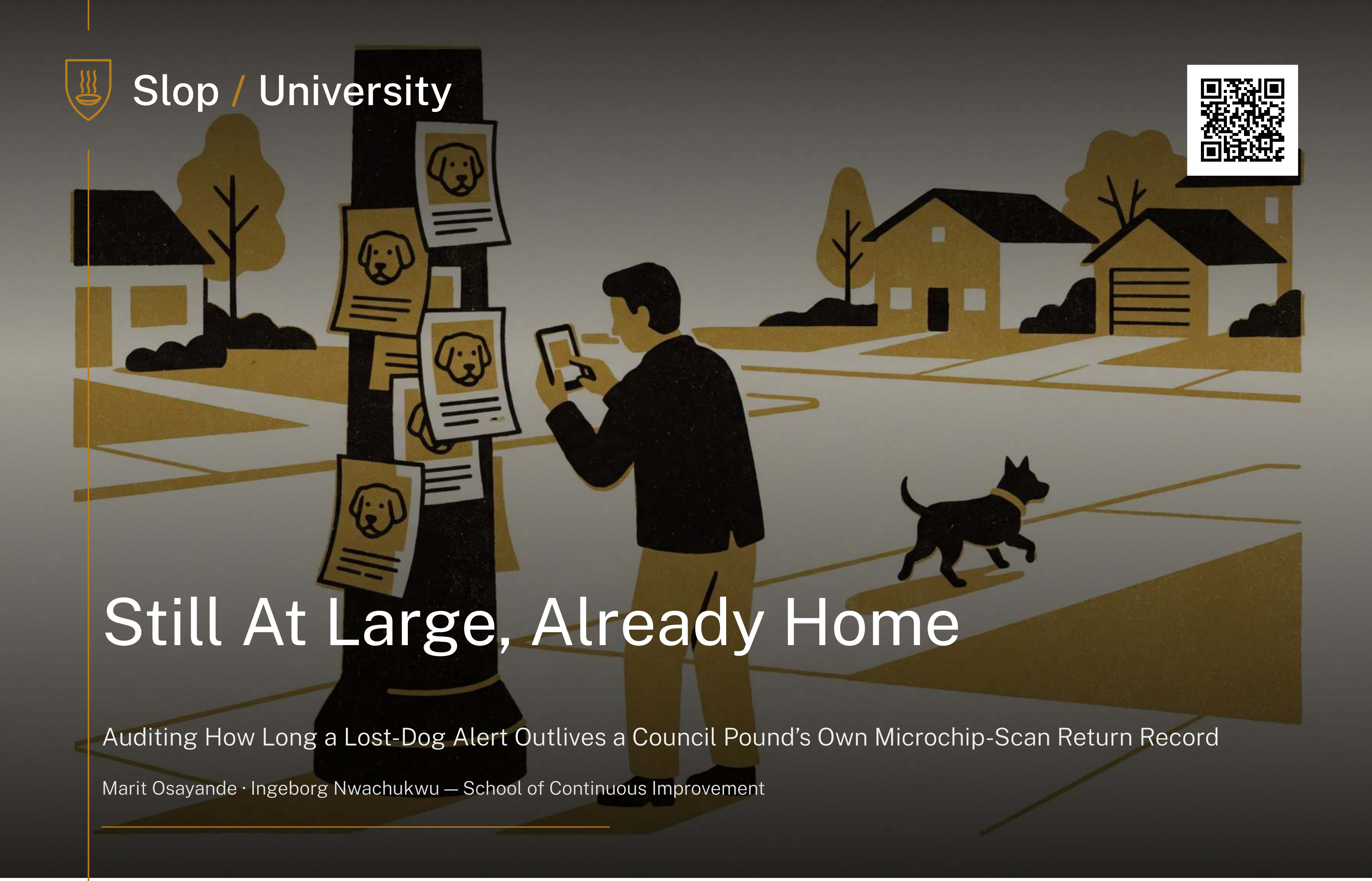

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Still At Large, Already Home

Auditing How Long a Lost-Dog Alert Outlives a Council Pound's Own Microchip-Scan Return Record

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The problem

Community lost-pet networks now run alongside council microchip registries as the record of where a missing dog stands. Little is known about how long a network's own alert outlives the registry entry that already closed the case.

Research questions

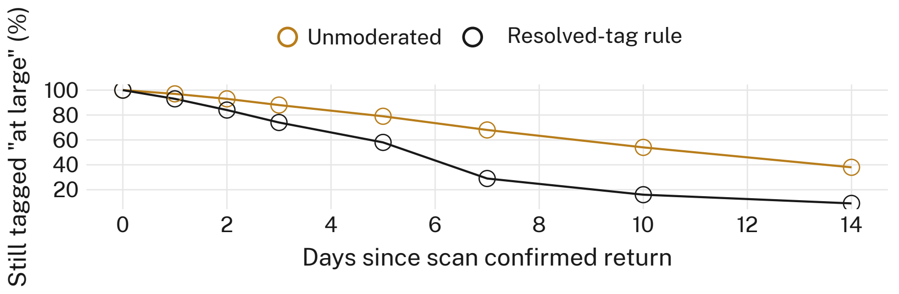
- How long does an alert lag a pound's microchip-scan return record?
- Does a mandatory "resolved" tag shorten that lag?
- Does an alert's engagement predict how long it persists unedited?

Study design

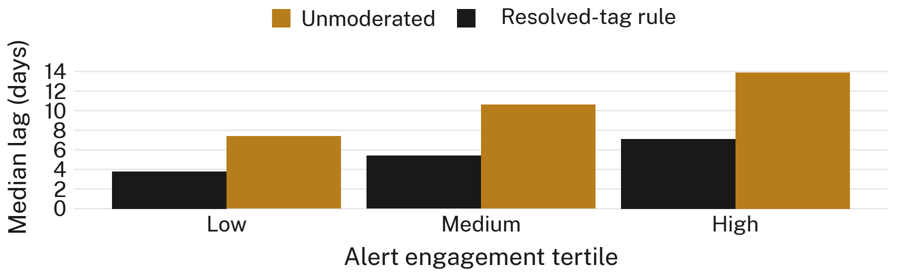
- n = 341 alerts · 14 suburb groups · 2 councils' scan logs · 11 months
- Daily status coded against each council's microchip-scan intake log
- Moderated (mandatory resolved tag, 6 groups) vs unmoderated (8 groups) held as the natural comparison; thresholds pre-registered

Findings

Alerts outlive the pound's own return record by a wide margin. A mandatory resolved-tag rule nearly halves the lag; it does not close it.



Seven days after a microchip scan confirmed a dog's return, 68% of unmoderated-group alerts still read "STILL AT LARGE," against 29% under a resolved-tag rule (n = 341); the rule cuts the median lag from 11.0 to 5.6 days without closing it.



The engagement gradient holds inside each condition: a heavily-shared alert's median lag runs 13.9 days unmoderated versus 7.4 for a quiet one in the same group — a group's moderation policy sets the floor, not the shape of the drift above it.

Implications

A rule that halves the lag still leaves the record wrong for the better part of a working week. Engagement predicted persistence better than group size did — a well-shared alert outlived a quiet one by nearly 2× under both regimes, suggesting the reach that helps a dog get found is the same reach that keeps the alert circulating once it no longer needs to. Next: testing whether a pound-fed auto-close bot changes poster behaviour, or just relocates the lag to a field the register doesn't audit.

Selected references

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Alert text coded from public posts only; no poster or commenter identity retained. We thank the fourteen monitored groups' moderators.

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